Bharat Jodo Yatra: An Expression and a Game Changer

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‘Pappu is going to walk across India,’ a friend abruptly announced one day. Being an ardent supporter of the ruling dispensation, he has always tried to needle me about anything Rahul Gandhi does, and he certainly did not miss this chance. To be honest, I was quite unaware of what he was talking about and only vaguely remembered a small news item about Rahul Gandhi’s walkathon. Such is the state of our media that one of the foremost leaders of India’s principal Opposition party got only a passing mention. Compelled to do my own research, I was shocked at what I read. Rahul Gandhi and a band of Congress leaders were proposing to walk almost 4,000 kilometres from the southernmost point of India to the northernmost! The Congress party claimed that the Bharat Jodo Yatra was an attempt to stitch together India’s social fabric, which was deliberately being torn along communal and divisive fault lines. It seemed noble enough, but was this feasible?

In fact, given the spate of fake news sweeping across India, my first thought was that this could be one. Then, after I had verified the veracity of the news, I assumed that the Yatra would most likely be a motorized one, interspersed with symbolic walks for photo-ops. Nevertheless, despite my nagging doubts and suspicions, I tuned into the Yatra’s launch at Kanyakumari. The flag-off itself was rather bleak and I actually dismissed it as a dud. I recall thinking what a colossal mistake this was. What was Rahul even trying to do? How could he possibly try to recreate Mahatma Gandhi’s march at a time when the reputation of the Mahatma himself was being publicly shredded by a sustained social media campaign sponsored by the